practically everyone here would favor the private proposal," he told Kennedy, referring to Khrushchev's first letter.[13]

Kennedy was outgunned and outvoted in his own ExCom. The key argument marshaled by his opponents was that making a deal with Khrushchev on Turkey would undermine American credibility with the NATO allies. "If we talked to the Turks, it would already be clear that we were trying to sell out our allies for our interests. That would be the view in all of NATO," argued Bundy. Kennedy demanded answers on what had been done to approach the Turks. He asked his aides to formulate a position on the second proposal, "because this is the one that's before us and before the world." Nothing helped. The president decided to sound a temporary retreat and play for time. "We first ought to get clarification from the Soviet Union of what they're talking about," proposed Kennedy. On that suggestion, everyone finally agreed.[14]

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KENNEDY LEFT THE EXCOM SESSION AROUND NOON TO ATTEND a meeting with American governors summoned to Washington to be asked to make civil defense preparations for a possible nuclear war. With the ExCom opposing a Cuba-Turkey deal, that prospect was becoming ever more real. The Chiefs of Staff were in the final stages of preparing their recommendation to Kennedy to execute a massive airstrike on Cuba as early as the next day, Sunday, October 28, or Monday, October 29. The strike would be followed by an invasion, the option favored by Robert Kennedy. A peaceful solution was clearly available, but Kennedy had difficulty taking the deal offered to him by Khrushchev.[15]

The official White House statement, released later that day, reflected Kennedy's defeat and his advisers' victory. It referred to "several inconsistent and conflicting proposals" made by Moscow in the previous twenty-four hours, stating that the crisis was about the threat posed by the Soviets to countries of the Western Hemisphere and that negotiations could start only after construction of the missile bases in Cuba stopped. That would make it possible to begin "seeking properly inspected arms